SANDINISTA REBELS

The Frente Sandinista de Liberación Nacional (FSLN – Sandinista National Liberation Front) was named after Augusto César Sandino, who launched an anti-American guerrilla campaign in Nicaragua in the 1920s. Sandino was assassinated in 1934 by the Somoza family, which established a US-backed dictatorship. The FSLN was founded in 1962 as a small Marxist guerrilla band in a remote area of Nicaragua. In the 1970s the unpopularity of the Somoza dictatorship allowed the Sandinistas to win the active support of the population. Despite a large-scale counterinsurgency campaign waged by the Somozan National Guard, by September 1978 most of Nicaragua was in Sandinista hands. In July 1979 the dictatorship collapsed after the United States withdrew its support. Ironically, in the 1980s the Sandinista regime was in its turn undermined by a ruthless guerrilla campaign, this time mounted by the US-armed and -financed Contras.



British L1A1
Many of these British army service rifles came to the Sandinistas from Belize, a one-time British colony.



Popular support
Sandinista rebels in a village under Sandinista control near the Honduras border, July 1983.

CUBAN REBEL ARMY

On 2 December 1956, Fidel Castro and 81 followers landed on the coast of Cuba intent upon overthrowing the dictatorship of Fulgencio Batista. An encounter with government forces, however, soon reduced their numbers to 22, and from May 1957 they carried out small-scale guerrilla raids to which the Cuban government could not respond. A government offensive in the mountains in spring 1958 was a disaster, with Batista's troops repeatedly defeated by the far inferior guerrilla forces. Meanwhile, the American government withdrew military support from the dictatorship. Then numbering several thousands, the guerrillas went on the offensive against the regime in August 1958. Forces led by an Argentinian doctor, Ernesto "Che" Guevara, marched into Havana on 1 January 1959.

> "A REVOLUTION IS A STRUGGLE TO THE DEATH BETWEEN THE FUTURE AND THE PAST."
>
> **FIDEL CASTRO**, SPEAKING IN HAVANA, 1 JAN 1961



Castro and his commanders
Fidel Castro and members of his staff planning a raid in 1957. Che Guevara is seated second from the right.

FARC

The FARC (Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia – Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia) was set up in the mid-1960s by Marxists claiming to be fighting on behalf of the Colombian people. From the 1980s, under the influence of Jacobo Arenas, it developed into a self-styled "army of the people" with a plan for mounting a military campaign to seize power in the country. Colombia's remote jungle and mountain regions provided safe havens that the guerrillas could control, while the country's coca crop offered a potential source of revenue to buy sophisticated arms. Although the FARC carried out a number of notable military operations in the 1990s, it has exhibited a tendency to degenerate into a simple criminal organization. It battles with Colombia's powerful right-wing paramilitary groups for control of the drugs trade and raises further finance by kidnapping, extortion, and protection rackets. However, in spite of the risks involved, joining the FARC might well seem a sensible career choice amid the poverty and insecurity of rural Colombia, since a member of the group is probably paid far higher than a person working in legitimate employment.